CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Monday, October 12, 2026

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RE: Wong presses Palestinian Authority on election delay · Fiji pledges $10m to Pacific Resilience Facility · NACC drops Lehrmann submarine secrets probe · Newspoll: major parties stuck below 30 percent · NZ election enters final stretch

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,783	0.6973	13,828	0.5599
+1.11%	+0.09%	+0.94%	0.00%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · Pacific · New Zealand · China-Pacific · Canberra · Markets · Upcoming · The Wire

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Wong called the Palestinian Authority's postponement of elections to September 2027 "deeply disappointing," as the Coalition argues recognition of Palestine came before conditions were met.
2. Fiji pledged $10 million to the Pacific Resilience Facility at Pre-COP31 in Nadi, lifting total pledges to $190 million against a $500 million initial capitalisation target.
3. New Zealand's election campaign sharpens with 26 days to go, Winston Peters predicting the fragmented MMP landscape will "stabilise" while Opportunity's Qiulae Wong says NZ First and ACT are trying to talk her party out of contention.

TOP STORIES

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Wong calls Palestinian election delay "deeply disappointing" as Coalition presses recognition timing

Penny Wong urged the Palestinian Authority to hold elections "without delay" after President **Mahmoud Abbas** postponed the November vote, which would have been the first Palestinian elections in two decades, until September 2027. "Continuing to delay elections undermines the prospects of a two-state solution," Wong said. The Coalition said **Anthony Albanese**'s decision to recognise Palestinian statehood before key conditions were met showed a "dangerous lack of judgement."

per ABC News: "Penny Wong urges Palestinian Authority to hold elections 'without delay'" · also SMH Federal Politics

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Fiji pledges $10 million to Pacific Resilience Facility as total tops $190 million

Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka** announced a *$10 million* Fijian contribution to the Pacific Resilience Facility at the Pre-COP31 meetings in Nadi. Denmark pledged $2.3 million and the Netherlands $1 million, lifting total pledges to $190 million against an initial $500 million capitalisation target and a longer-term $1.5 billion goal. Forum Secretary-General **Baron Divavesi Waqa** called it "Pacific-led action on climate change."

per Islands Business: "Fiji pledges $10m to Pacific Resilience Facility"

AU-POLITICS

Anti-corruption watchdog abandons Lehrmann submarine secrets investigation

The National Anti-Corruption Commission told **Bruce Lehrmann** it has abandoned its probe into his alleged removal of classified French submarine material from former defence minister **Linda Reynolds**'s office. Officials raided his home in June 2024 under Operation Ivanhoe, seizing a diary the government said held eight pages of classified information. Lehrmann is separately suing Special Minister of State **Don Farrell** and former commissioner **Paul Brereton** over the raid.

per ABC News: "Corruption watchdog abandons Bruce Lehrmann submarine secrets probe"

OVERNIGHT

TRADE-ECONOMY

Lowy Institute finds South-East Asia aid at a decade low · ABC News

Official development finance to South-East Asia fell nearly *10 percent* to $US26 billion in 2024, the lowest in a decade, according to the Lowy Institute's South-East Asia Aid Map. Japan cut funding by $US1.5 billion as COVID-era lending matured. Lead author **Rahul Nath** said "traditional donors are in retreat... and China is cutting aid rather than stepping in to fill the gap."

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Engineer Robert Pether leaves Iraq five years after fraud arrest · ABC News

Robert Pether, jailed in 2021 on fraud charges tied to the new Central Bank of Iraq headquarters and fined $16 million, has left Baghdad, Wong confirmed. Released from prison in June 2025 but barred from leaving Iraq, the 51-year-old departed with Australia's ambassador **Glenn Miles** and is travelling to reunite with family in Ireland.

US-AUSTRALIA

Canberra says platforms bear "responsibility" to block US execution livestream · Guardian AU politics

The federal government said online platforms have a "responsibility" to stop Australians viewing the Pentagon's planned livestream of the firing-squad execution of **Nidal Malik Hasan**, scheduled for December 3. The communications department warned broadcasters to "act responsibly," while government sources conceded limits on what Canberra can compel platforms to do.

AU-DEFENSE

Barton's secretive security precinct to house ONI, DFAT and 5,000 staff · ABC News

Six cranes are working on Canberra's biggest Commonwealth construction project in almost forty years, a National Security Office Precinct in Barton for the Office of National Intelligence and the Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade. Finance official **Nick McClintock** told Senate estimates in May the department is still engaging other agencies on the build, which will host up to 5,000 workers.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Emirati investigators trace flydubai attack suspect's radicalisation to Melbourne · New York Times

Emirati investigators said the co-pilot accused of attacking a captain aboard a flight to Israel became radicalised while studying in Melbourne, naming a local mosque in connection with the case. Melbourne imam **Samir Mohtadi**, linked to the centre, has rejected what he called "false accusations."

STAT OF THE DAY

78,000

Older Australians expected to drop private health cover by 2030

FOI data obtained by the ABC nearly doubles the government's previously cited 44,000 estimate, intensifying the Senate fight over private health rebate changes.

ABC News

PACIFIC WIRE

TUVALU · ISLANDS BUSINESS

PNG pledges PGK25 million over five years for Tuvalu land reclamation

James Marape announced Papua New Guinea will give Tuvalu PGK5 million (about AUD$1.59 million) annually for five years to support land reclamation against rising seas, during a joint press conference with Tuvalu's **Feleti Teo** at the Pre-COP31 leaders' segment in Fiji. Marape called the pledge a reflection of "Pacific solidarity."

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

US report says PNG logging industry "heavily implicated" in trafficking

A United States government report finds human trafficking of foreign nationals and locals is prevalent across Papua New Guinea's logging industry, with endemic corruption leaving the government making "minimal" efforts to prevent it. The findings were flagged by anti-corruption group ACT NOW!, which campaigns on the sector's governance failures.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Indonesian naval hospital ship treats patients in Fiji on Pacific tour

The Indonesian naval hospital ship KRI dr. Wahidin Sudirohusodo-991 is docked in Fiji from October 9 to 13, part of a goodwill mission that already treated 656 patients and performed 14 surgeries in Vanuatu. The tour continues to Solomon Islands and Papua New Guinea through November 12, with Jakarta describing itself as a "Strategic Partner" of the Pacific Islands Forum.

COOK ISLANDS · RNZ WORLD

Foreign national stranded in Cook Islands three years after visa refusals

A South Asian national has been unable to leave the Cook Islands since arriving in November 2023 because neither New Zealand nor Australia has approved a transit visa for her return home, despite Cook Islands officials pressing Wellington since April 2025. Principal immigration officer **Chere Arthur** said the delay reflects difficulty obtaining transit visas through other countries, not a lack of effort.

NIUE · RNZ NATIONAL

Niue declares yellow alert as drought threat sparks wildfires

Niue's disaster management office has placed the island on a yellow alert over an "imminent threat" of drought, after wildfires broke out in several areas and prompted a total burn ban.

FIJI · RNZ NATIONAL

Second explicit video implicating Fiji cabinet minister surfaces on Facebook

A second intimate video involving a Fijian cabinet minister appeared on Facebook on the eve of Fiji Day, the government's second such scandal in as many days. Prime Minister Rabuka has challenged accusers to provide evidence against the minister involved.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · REUTERS

NZ First's culture-war push shows limited appeal, analysts say

Analysts tell Reuters that New Zealand First's culture-war policies are struggling to gain traction even as similar politics surges elsewhere, ahead of New Zealand's November 7 general election. The party has leaned into contested social issues as part of its pitch within the National-led coalition.

NZ-POLITICS · REUTERS

Reuters maps the parties vying to form New Zealand's next government

Reuters outlines the main parties contesting New Zealand's November 7 election, as polling points to a fragmented outcome under MMP. Coalition arithmetic among National, Labour, ACT, NZ First and smaller parties remains unsettled, with advance voting opening October 26.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ POLITICAL

Peters says New Zealand politics will "stabilise" despite fragmented MMP landscape

Winston Peters, New Zealand's most experienced sitting political leader, said he does not believe the country's politics is becoming permanently fragmented despite polling suggesting three or four parties may be needed to form government. Thirty years after MMP's first election, Peters said "things are going to be stabilised at the end of this event."

NZ-POLITICS · STUFF

Opportunity's Qiulae Wong says she feels "threatened" after Peters, Seymour doubt her party

Qiulae Wong, leader of New Zealand's Opportunity party, said she felt "threatened" after NZ First's Winston Peters and ACT's **David Seymour** both said they do not believe Opportunity will clear parliament's threshold, despite most polls showing the party above the 5 percent mark ahead of the November 7 New Zealand election.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

REGIONAL · SECURITY/POLICING · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

China's expanding police presence reshapes Pacific security landscape, report finds

A Geneva-based Global Initiative Against Transnational Organized Crime report finds Chinese policing assistance has accelerated "in moments of unrest or political crisis" across the Blue Pacific, unsettling traditional partners Australia, New Zealand and the United States. Offers of assistance are framed as respecting sovereignty and free of conditionality, though often tied, explicitly or implicitly, to other commitments, the report finds.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · THE CONVERSATION AU

Newspoll: Albanese, Taylor and Hanson all stuck below 30 percent primary vote

The latest Newspoll shows **Anthony Albanese**, Opposition Leader **Angus Taylor** and One Nation's **Pauline Hanson** all holding primary support below *30 percent*, with Labor and the Greens improving while One Nation eased back, according to The Australian and The Conversation's analysis of Newspoll and Resolve data.

AU-POLITICS · GUARDIAN AUSTRALIA

Greens demand right to sue Big Tech as price for digital duty of care bill

The Greens will push Labor to let individuals sue platforms and win compensation, and to levy eSafety Commissioner fines as a share of corporations' global revenue, as the price of support for the government's digital duty of care laws due in parliament this week. **Sarah Hanson-Young** and **David Shoebridge** are leading the push.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

"Bully boy" accusations fly as government fights to keep nuclear waste FOI secret

The Albanese government is resisting the release of Freedom of Information documents on nuclear waste policy, drawing "bully boy" accusations from crossbench senator **Jacqui Lambie** and others over the secrecy.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Taylor rebuffs Frydenberg's call for GST reform

Opposition Leader Angus Taylor dismissed former treasurer **Josh Frydenberg**'s call to reform the GST, as Coalition MPs query Taylor's economic messaging amid speculation about Frydenberg's return to federal politics.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

FOI data nearly doubles estimate of Australians set to drop private health cover

Health department analysis released under Freedom of Information laws shows *78,000* Australians aged 65 and over are expected to drop private health cover by 2030, almost double the 44,000 figure the government has repeatedly cited. The Coalition said Health Minister **Mark Butler** had used the smaller number to defend rebate changes expected to bank about $3 billion for aged care.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Gas reservation scheme loopholes could let GLNG escape domestic obligations

Industry players say the federal government's draft gas reservation scheme, which would force exporters to set aside up to *20 percent* of production for the domestic market, contains carve-outs that could let the Santos-led GLNG venture in Queensland reduce or eliminate its exposure. An ABC investigation found GLNG has exported the equivalent of 20 percent of eastern Australia's domestic gas demand over the past decade.

TRADE-ECONOMY · POLITICO

Trade minister says Australia-EU free trade deal is "done," presses Opposition

Australia's trade minister told Politico "the deal is done" on the Australia-EU free trade agreement and increased pressure on the Opposition to back it, after talks collapsed in 2023 over agricultural market access.

UPCOMING

OCT 13

Indonesian naval hospital ship KRI dr. Wahidin Sudirohusodo-991 concludes Fiji port visit

Caps a Pacific goodwill tour already through Vanuatu and continuing to Solomon Islands and PNG, part of Jakarta's bid to position itself as a Pacific Islands Forum strategic partner.

OCT 26

Advance voting opens for New Zealand's general election

Marks the start of formal voting ahead of a fragmented MMP contest that polls suggest may need three or four parties to form government.

NOV 7

New Zealand general election

Decides whether the National-ACT-NZ First coalition continues, with Opportunity's Qiulae Wong a potential kingmaker if her party clears the threshold.

DEC 3

Scheduled livestreamed execution of Nidal Malik Hasan by US firing squad

Has triggered cross-parliament calls in Canberra to block the broadcast, testing how far Australian regulators can restrict US military content.

THE WIRE

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Pacific governments turn to social protection, not subsidies, for fuel price shock

Devpolicy's **Jesse Doyle** finds Fiji, Tonga, the Marshall Islands and Tuvalu are each cushioning fuel price rises through social protection systems rather than subsidies, under a program funded by Australia's Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

ASPI STRATEGIST

ASPI: Australia cannot achieve full sovereignty in imported AI models

The ASPI Strategist argues Australian "sovereign" AI ambitions are illusory given layered dependencies on chips, cloud infrastructure, energy and foreign model development, warning that imported models carry geopolitical baggage from their countries of origin.

AU-DEFENSE

ASPI STRATEGIST

ASPI: Australia's resilience push now needs implementation, not more strategy

The ASPI Strategist says Australia has spent several years "rediscovering" the importance of sovereign capability and economic security, but argues the harder task now is implementing resilience against concentrated supply chains and coercion.

AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

155mm artillery shell manufacture "on track"

Australian Defence Magazine reports domestic manufacture of 155mm artillery shells remains on schedule, part of the government's push to build sovereign munitions production capacity.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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